

THE POLIO FIGHT
A nurse at a Delhi hospital administers polio drops to an infant, Dec. 9, 1995

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PULSE POLIO CAMPAIGN, 1994

A COUNTRY VERSUS A VIRUS

From being the epicentre of a dreaded disease that left children with permanent disability, India achieved the impossible task of eradicating polio through a sustained, concerted effort by the government, NGOs and members of the local communities

BY SONALI ACHARJEE

In the 1980s, India was among the four countries where poliomyelitis, the dreaded disease that afflicts children under five and leaves them with a permanent disability, was endemic, contributing 200,000 cases per year. Nigeria, Afghanistan and Pakistan were the other three nations where the scourge ran rampant. A sustained, multi-actor effort and a successful immunisation programme, kickstarted with the Pulse Polio vaccination campaign by the Narasimha Rao government in 1995, chased the virus out of India. The country reported its last case of poliovirus 14 years ago, on January 13, 2011, in Howrah, West Bengal. The World Health Organization declared India polio-free in 2014, after the mandated three years without a single case had lapsed.

A virus that attacks the central nervous system and causes irreversible paralysis in extreme cases, polio is transmitted from person to person through the faecal-oral route. With poor sanitation, poverty and crowded living spaces, the task of ending polio would not be an easy one in India. Making it even harder was trying to track the disease in hard-to-reach areas, among communities on the move, coupled with vaccine hesitancy among certain populations. The disease cannot be considered gone as long as even one child is infected.

India launched its first large-scale vaccination campaign on October 2, Gandhi Jayanti, in 1994 in Delhi, replicating it on a national scale from the next year onward. As part of the programme, an Oral Polio Vaccine (OPV) was to reach over 1 million children. Mass vaccination campaigns, requiring over 2 million vaccinators at a time, reached every household. In 1997, the government and WHO established the National Polio Surveillance Project (NPSP) to monitor the reporting of polio cases in India. Funding and resources were also concentrated in two states—Uttar Pradesh and Bihar—which had become the epicentre of the disease in the country. In 2017, the government also